

welcome in the West. In the early 1960s the focus of hijacking was Cuba, recently taken over by Fidel Castro's guerrillas. In May 1961 a man armed with a knife and a gun ordered the pilot of a National Airlines service from Miami to Key West to fly him to Havana. It was America's first hijacking and made "Take this plane to Cuba" a catchphrase. In response, hijacking became a federal offense in the United States and air authorities worldwide agreed to counter it. But in practice little was done. Until the 1970s boarding an aircraft anywhere in the world was a casual matter, involving no more than, where appropriate, the long-established formalities of passport control and customs checks.

In these lax circumstances, by the late 1960s hijacking had become a growing epidemic, with 33 occurrences in 1968 and 91 in 1969. Many were carried out by disturbed individuals with no clear rational motivation. Some were straight-



forwardly mercenary – as in the case of the hijacker who registered as D.B. Cooper on a Boeing 727 flight in Washington state in 1971, and parachuted out of the aircraft with \$200,000 ransom money in a sack, never to be seen again. But the most frightening trend was set in the summer of 1968, when members of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine diverted an El Al airliner to Algiers and held the Israeli passengers hostage, negotiating the release of Arab prisoners in Israel. An impressively successful operation from the Palestinian point of view, it revealed that airliners constituted a vulnerable point at which otherwise well-defended states – and world capitalism – could be attacked, with potential for maximum propaganda impact on the media. As the world entered the era of international terrorism, airliners and airports found themselves in the front line.

Terrorist operations

By 1970 three types of terrorist operation had become established: hijacking and hostage-taking; attacks on passengers and airliners on the ground, initiated at Athens airport in December 1968; and the planting of bombs on board airliners set to explode in midair. Palestinian groups soon extended their attacks from Israeli targets

SCATTERED WRECKAGE

Accident investigators had an awesome task after the Lockerbie bombing in 1988. Because the explosion took place at high altitude, the wreckage was spread over 850 square miles (2,200 square km) of countryside. Evidence from the wreckage eventually helped to convict two Libyans.

to all Western airlines, both because the US had emerged as Israel's main backer in the Middle East, and because they had learned to identify their local cause with a worldwide struggle against "Western imperialism." In September 1970, an astonishing terrorist spectacular was staged involving the hijacking

of four airliners (a fifth hijack attempt was foiled). One of the planes, a Pan Am 747, was flown to Cairo and blown up on the ground after the passengers and crew had been moved off. The three others – a Swissair DC-8, a TWA Boeing 707, and a BOAC VC-10 – were diverted to the Dawson's Field airstrip in Jordan. After lengthy negotiations, the hostages were also removed from these aircraft and they too were blown up. Staged in front of the world's TV cameras, this blazing funeral pyre of prized Western technology was a symbolic gesture skillfully crafted to appeal to the powerless and poverty-stricken peoples of the Middle East and beyond.

Security measures

The response of governments and air authorities to the rising tide of hijackings and terrorism was patchy and often laggardly. Israel and its airline, El Al, understandably introduced the most rigorous security measures and were scornful of the reluctance of other countries and airlines to spend sufficient money or impose the delays and restrictions on their passengers that safety required. Yet much was done. In the United



ENTEBBE RETURN

A crowd at Lod airport, Tel Aviv, welcomes back Israeli soldiers and freed hostages after the raid on Entebbe in July 1976. In the background is one of the C-130 Hercules transports used in the raid.

